

Chapter 1: The Worst Customer in Silver Harbor

Jenny had been on her feet for eleven hours.

The dinner rush had finally begun, and the Golden Dragon Restaurant was packed.

Steam rose from bowls of noodles.

Customers talked over one another.

Plates clattered.

And Jenny moved through it all with practiced ease.

"Table seven needs tea."

"Coming."

"Table twelve wants extra dumplings."

"Got it."

"Jenny, don't forget table three."

"I know, Bao."

Bao grinned.

"You always know."

Jenny rolled her eyes and balanced three plates on one arm.

The restaurant was chaos.

The good kind of chaos.

The kind that paid the bills.

The kind that helped her send money home every month.

Her parents depended on her.

So did her younger brother.

Failure wasn't an option.

Not for Jenny.

Not anymore.

The front door opened.

A cool breeze swept through the dining room.

Several customers looked up.

Jenny didn't.

At least not right away.

Then the room grew strangely quiet.

She glanced toward the entrance.

A tall man stepped inside.

He wore a dark tailored coat.

Everything about him looked expensive.

His watch.

His shoes.

Even the way he carried himself.

As if the world belonged to him.

The hostess immediately rushed over.

"Welcome, sir."

The man barely acknowledged her.

His eyes swept across the restaurant.

Calculating.

Judging.

Evaluating.

Jenny instantly disliked him.

Something about him felt cold.

The hostess guided him to a table near the window.

Bao appeared beside Jenny.

"Oh no."

"What?"

Bao leaned closer.

"That's Austin Blackwood."

Jenny frowned.

"Should I know who that is?"

Bao looked horrified.

"Only one of the richest traders in Lunaria."

Jenny shrugged.

"So?"

Bao stared.

"Jenny, some people dream of serving people like him."

"I dream of serving customers who don't complain."

Bao laughed.

"You haven't even talked to him yet."

"I already know he's trouble."

As if the universe had heard her.

A hand lifted from the corner table.

Austin Blackwood wanted service.

Jenny grabbed a menu.

"Wish me luck."

"You'll need it."

She approached the table.

"Good evening, sir."

Austin looked up.

For a brief moment, their eyes met.

Dark eyes.

Sharp eyes.

The kind that noticed everything.

His gaze moved over her.

The messy dark hair.

The oversized glasses.

The simple uniform.

Then he looked away.

As if she'd failed some invisible inspection.

"I'll have the Imperial Seafood Noodles."

His voice was calm.

Cold.

"And jasmine tea."

"Anything else?"

"No."

Jenny waited.

Nothing.

No please.

No smile.

No thank you.

Wonderful.

She forced a professional smile.

"I'll bring that right out."

As she turned away, she heard him speak again.

"Make sure it's fresh."

Jenny stopped.

Slowly.

She looked back.

"Our food is always fresh."

Austin raised an eyebrow.

"We'll see."

Jenny walked away before she said something that would get her fired.

Twenty minutes later, she returned with his order.

The noodles smelled amazing.

The broth was rich.

The seafood perfectly prepared.

She placed the bowl in front of him.

"Enjoy your meal."

Austin nodded.

Nothing more.

Jenny moved on with her shift.

For almost thirty minutes, everything seemed fine.

Then it happened.

A loud voice cut through the restaurant.

"Excuse me."

Conversations stopped.

Jenny closed her eyes.

Of course.

Of course it was him.

She turned around.

Austin stood beside his table.

Holding something between two fingers.

A long dark strand of hair.

The entire restaurant stared.

Jenny's stomach dropped.

Austin's expression was ice cold.

"I'd like to speak with the manager."

The room fell silent.

And for the first time that night, Jenny had a feeling this was only the beginning of her problems.

Because Austin Blackwood wasn't finished.

Not even close.